

Chapter 7 — The Making of Regional Cultures

The one-line point: Tamil, Malayalam, Bengali, Kathak, Rajput heroism, Kangra painting — none of these are "ancient and unchanging." **Every one was MADE, in this period, by mixing local tradition with outside influence.** ★ Pure Art & Culture; very high Prelims value.

← Ch.6 | Index | Next: Ch.8 →

Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Medieval India → ★ ART & CULTURE
Sub-discipline	Cultural history — language, dance, painting, architecture, foodways
Period	~9th – 19th centuries
Prelims (GS Paper I)	★★★★ <i>Art & Culture</i> — classical dances, painting schools, temple styles are perennial
Mains (GS Paper I)	★★★★ " <i>Salient aspects of Art Forms, Literature and Architecture</i> " — this chapter is that syllabus line
Also feeds	Art & Culture ★★★★★, Indian Society (regional identity, language and the states question), Polity (linguistic reorganisation of states), Essay (unity in diversity)
Weightage	★★★★★ — high, almost entirely through Art & Culture
Overlaps with	Ch.6 (bhakti drives Kathak and Bengali literature), Ch.4 (Mughal miniatures), Ch.8 (regional courts)

 **Treat this as an Art & Culture chapter that happens to sit in a History book.** The dance and painting material is asked far more often than the political history around it.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Explain** NCERT's central claim: regional cultures are **made**, not inherited unchanged. ★
- ☐ **Describe** the Chera contribution to **Malayalam**, and define *Manipravalam*. ★★
- ☐ **Narrate** the **Jagannatha cult** and explain **why conquerors sought control of the temple**. ★★
- ☐ **Describe** the Rajput heroic ideal, the role of **minstrels**, and the place of women in it. ★
- ☐ **Trace Kathak** from temple story-tellers to classical dance, naming the **two gharanas** and their patrons. ★★★★★
- ☐ **Name** the six classical dance forms and their states. ★★
- ☐ **State NCERT's critique** of the word "classical". ★
- ☐ **Trace** miniature painting from Jaina manuscripts → Mughal court → **Basohli** → **Kangra**. ★★★★★
- ☐ **Explain** how **Bengali** emerged, and the **two categories** of early Bengali literature. ★★
- ☐ **Explain** who the *pirs* were and why their cult spread. ★★
- ☐ **Describe** the **Bengali temple style** — *dochala, chauchala*, terracotta, **Vishnupur**. ★★

- ☐ **Explain** the **fish exemption** and what it shows about local practice shaping textual rule. ★★

Start Here: The Claim That Frames Everything

We describe people by the language they speak — a Tamil, an Oriya — and associate each region with **distinctive food, clothes, poetry, dance, music and painting**.

★ "Sometimes we take these identities for granted and assume that they have existed FROM TIME IMMEMORIAL. However, the frontiers separating regions have EVOLVED OVER TIME (and in fact are STILL CHANGING). Also, what we understand as regional cultures today are often the PRODUCT OF COMPLEX PROCESSES OF INTERMIXING of local traditions with ideas from other parts of the subcontinent."

THREE PATTERNS NCERT IDENTIFIES

- [1] Some practices are DISTINCTIVE to particular regions
- [2] Others seem SIMILAR ACROSS regions
- [3] Others derive from OLDER PRACTICES in a particular area, but take a NEW FORM in other regions

 **This is a genuinely important corrective and prime Essay material.** Regional identity feels primordial and is in fact **recent and constructed**. Kathak became "classical" only **after independence**; Bengali reached a common literary form only in the **15th century**; Malayalam entered official records in the **9th**.

 These are **forks that diverged, exchanged patches, and were later declared canonical** — the "ancient tradition" is a snapshot of a still-running process, retrospectively frozen and labelled.

1 ★★ **Language and Region: The Cheras and Malayalam**

Fact	Detail
The kingdom	The Chera kingdom of MAHODAYAPURAM , established in the ★ NINTH century in the south-western part of the peninsula — part of present-day Kerala
★★ The innovation	The rulers introduced the MALAYALAM language and script in their INSCRIPTIONS — "one of the earliest examples of the use of a REGIONAL LANGUAGE in OFFICIAL RECORDS in the subcontinent "
But also Sanskrit	The Cheras also drew upon Sanskrit traditions . The temple theatre of Kerala , traced to this period, borrowed stories from the Sanskrit epics
First literary works	In Malayalam, dated to about the twelfth century , and directly indebted to Sanskrit
★★ MANIPRAVALAM	A fourteenth-century text, the LILATILAKAM, dealing with GRAMMAR and POETICS , was composed in Manipravalam — literally ★ " DIAMONDS AND CORALS ", referring to the two languages, Sanskrit and the regional language

★ **Manipravalam** is a favourite Prelims item and a beautiful metaphor: **two precious materials strung on one thread**, neither dissolving into the other. It names exactly what this chapter is about — **regional culture as a deliberate blend**, not a replacement.

💡 **Remember: mani = gem/diamond, pravalam = coral. Sanskrit + Malayalam. Text = Lilatilakam, 14th century.**

2 ★★ Religion and Region: The Jagannatha Cult at Puri

Fact	Detail
The name	Jagannatha literally = ★ "lord of the world", a name for VISHNU
Where	PURI, Orissa (Odisha)
★★ The tribal origin	"To date, the LOCAL TRIBAL PEOPLE make the WOODEN IMAGE of the deity" — which suggests the deity was originally a local tribal deity, later identified with Vishnu
12th century	ANANTAVARMAN , one of the most important rulers of the GANGA dynasty , decided to erect a temple for Purushottama Jagannatha at Puri
★ 1230	King ANANGABHIMA III dedicated his kingdom to the deity and proclaimed himself the "DEPUTY" of the god
★★ The consequence	As the temple gained importance as a centre of pilgrimage , its authority in SOCIAL and POLITICAL matters also increased
★★ Why conquerors wanted it	All those who conquered Orissa — the MUGHALS , the MARATHAS and the ENGLISH EAST INDIA COMPANY — attempted to gain control over the temple. They felt this would "make their rule ACCEPTABLE TO THE LOCAL PEOPLE "

★★★ This is the chapter's best single case study, and it answers two exam questions at once.

First, the absorption mechanism (Ch.6 again): a tribal wooden deity becomes **Vishnu** — but the tribal people **keep the right to carve the image**, to this day. The local is not erased; it is **incorporated with its role preserved**. That is why the tradition held.

Second, religion as political infrastructure: by declaring himself the god's **deputy**, Anangabhima III made the deity the sovereign and himself the administrator. Any later conqueror therefore had to capture the temple, not merely the territory — because legitimacy resided there. **Three successive imperial powers, including the British, understood this and acted on it.**

🎯 NCERT's own question — "why did conquerors try to control the temple of Jagannatha?" — is a standard exam question with exactly this answer.

3 ★ The Rajputs and Traditions of Heroism

Fact	Detail
The name	In the nineteenth century the British called the region that is most of present-day Rajasthan ★ " RAJPUTANA "
⚠️ The caveat	This is only partly true — several groups identify as Rajputs across northern and central India , and many peoples other than Rajputs live in Rajasthan
Rule	From about the eighth century , most of present-day Rajasthan was ruled by various Rajput families — Prithviraj (Ch.2) was one such ruler
★ The heroic ideal	The hero " fought valiantly, often choosing DEATH ON THE BATTLEFIELD RATHER THAN FACE DEFEAT "
★ The medium	Stories recorded in poems and songs , recited by ★ specially trained MINSTRELS
Their purpose	To preserve the memories of heroes and inspire others to follow their example
Their popular appeal	Ordinary people were attracted by dramatic situations and a range of strong emotions — loyalty, friendship, love, valour, anger

⚠️ ★ Women in these stories

Women are sometimes depicted as **following their heroic husbands in both life and death** — there are stories about the practice of **SATI**, the immolation of widows on the funeral pyre of their husbands.

★ "So those who followed the heroic ideal often had to pay for it with THEIR LIVES."

🎯 NCERT's placement of that sentence is deliberate and worth noticing. The heroic ideal is not presented as simple glory — it is presented as **a code that killed the people who lived by it, and killed women who had not chosen it at all.**

★ **Strong GS1 material on gender:** the celebration of *jauhar* and *sati* in heroic literature is how a coercive practice was rendered as honour. Connect forward to **Raja Ram Mohan Roy and the abolition of sati (1829)** — Class 8, Ch.7, *Women, Caste and Reform*.

🔗 Also connect back: the **first epigraphic record of sati** is the **Eran inscription, 510 CE** (Class 6 Ch.9).

4 ★ ★ ★ Beyond Regional Frontiers: The Story of Kathak

The single most-asked item in this chapter.

THE EVOLUTION OF KATHAK

ORIGIN

"KATHAK" derives from KATHA -- a word used in Sanskrit and other languages for STORY.

The KATHAKS were originally a CASTE OF STORY-TELLERS in TEMPLES of north India, who embellished their performances with GESTURES and SONGS.

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15th - 16th CENTURIES : THE BHAKTI TURN

Kathak began evolving into a DISTINCT MODE OF DANCE with the spread of the BHAKTI MOVEMENT.

Legends of RADHA-KRISHNA were enacted in folk plays called *** RASA LILA ***, which combined FOLK DANCE with the basic GESTURES of the story-tellers.

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MUGHAL PERIOD : THE COURT TURN

Under the MUGHAL EMPERORS AND THEIR NOBLES, Kathak was performed IN THE COURT, where it ACQUIRED ITS PRESENT FEATURES and developed into a distinctive style.

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TWO GHARANAS (traditions)

[1] the courts of RAJASTHAN (JAIPUR)

[2] LUCKNOW -- under the patronage of *** WAJID ALI SHAH ***, the LAST NAWAB OF AWADH, it grew into a major art form

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BY THE 3rd QUARTER OF THE 19th CENTURY

Firmly entrenched not only in those two regions but in PUNJAB, HARYANA, JAMMU AND KASHMIR, BIHAR and MADHYA PRADESH. Emphasis on INTRICATE AND RAPID FOOTWORK, ELABORATE COSTUMES, and the ENACTMENT OF STORIES.

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COLONIAL DISFAVOUR

Viewed with DISFAVOUR by most BRITISH ADMINISTRATORS in the 19th and 20th centuries. It SURVIVED and continued to be performed by *** COURTESANS ***...

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...and was recognised as ONE OF THE SIX "CLASSICAL" FORMS OF DANCE *** AFTER INDEPENDENCE ***.

★★ Three facts from that chain get asked constantly:

1. **Kathak came from temple story-tellers** (*katha* = story), **not** from the court
2. **Two gharanas: Jaipur and Lucknow**, the latter under **Wajid Ali Shah**
3. It was **preserved by courtesans** through colonial disapproval and **classicised only after 1947**

🎯 **That third point is genuinely important for a Mains answer on cultural nationalism:** the "classical" status of Indian dance forms is a **post-independence act of national canon-formation**, and the women who actually kept the tradition alive — courtesans — were **stigmatised** in the process. **A tradition was rescued and its custodians were written out.**

👯 ★★★ The six classical dance forms

Dance	State
KATHAK	North India (Jaipur & Lucknow gharanas)
BHARATANATYAM	Tamil Nadu
KATHAKALI	Kerala
ODISSI	Odisha
KUCHIPUDI	Andhra Pradesh
MANIPURI	Manipur

🔗 **Memory hook: "KA-BHA-KA-O-KU-MA."** (Note: the officially recognised list today includes *Sattriya* from Assam and *Mohiniyattam* from Kerala, making eight — but NCERT names these six. If a question specifies "as per NCERT", use six.)

★ NCERT's critique of the word "classical" — quotable

*"The question of defining any art form as 'classical' is often quite complicated. Do we define something as classical if it deals with a **religious theme**? Or because it appears to require **a great deal of skill acquired through long years of training**? Or because it is **performed according to rules that are laid down, and variations are not encouraged**?... Many dance forms that are classified as 'folk' also **share several of the characteristics considered typical of 'classical' forms**. So, while the use of the term 'classical' may suggest that these forms are **superior, this need not always be literally true.**"*

🔗 **Excellent for Essay and for GS1 on cultural hierarchy.** The classical/folk boundary is a **judgement about status dressed up as a description of form**. Deploy it in any answer about whose culture gets preserved and valorised.

5 ★★★ Painting for Patrons: The Tradition of Miniatures

Basics	Detail
What	Small-sized paintings, generally in ★ WATER COLOUR on CLOTH or PAPER
Earliest	On ★ PALM LEAVES or WOOD
★ Earliest famous group	Found in WESTERN INDIA, used to illustrate ★ JAINA TEXTS

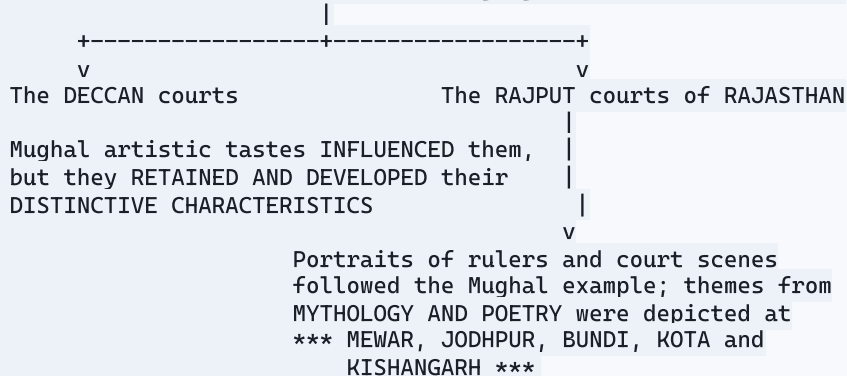
👑 The Mughal miniature

Aspect	Detail
Patrons	★ AKBAR, JAHANGIR and SHAH JAHAN
What they painted	Primarily illustrated manuscripts containing HISTORICAL ACCOUNTS and POETRY
Style and subject	Brilliant colours; court scenes, scenes of battle or hunting, and other aspects of social life
★ Their circulation	Often exchanged as GIFTS and viewed only by an EXCLUSIVE FEW — the emperor and his close associates

🎯 **That last row matters.** Mughal miniatures were **not public art**. They were **private, elite, diplomatic objects** — which is precisely why they survived in such good condition (kept in palaces) and why they tell us about the court and not about ordinary life.

🏰 ★ ★ The dispersal — and the birth of the Pahari schools

With the DECLINE OF THE MUGHAL EMPIRE, many painters MOVED OUT to the courts of the emerging REGIONAL STATES (Ch.8)



And in the Himalayan foothills (modern Himachal Pradesh):

School	Detail
★ ★ BASOHLI	By the late seventeenth century this region developed a ★ BOLD AND INTENSE style. The most popular text painted here was ★ BHANUDATTA'S RASAMANJARI
★ ★ KANGRA	★ Nadir Shah's invasion and the conquest of Delhi in 1739 caused the migration of Mughal artists to the hills to escape the uncertainties of the plains. There they found ready patrons → the founding of the Kangra school . By the ★ mid-eighteenth century Kangra artists developed a style that "breathed a new spirit into miniature painting". Inspired by ★ VAISHNAVITE traditions ; distinguished by ★ SOFT COLOURS INCLUDING COOL BLUES AND GREENS, and a LYRICAL TREATMENT of themes

💡 **The contrast to remember: BASOHLI = BOLD AND INTENSE. KANGRA = SOFT, COOL BLUES AND GREENS, LYRICAL.** That pairing is a classic Prelims match, and the trigger for Kangra is **1739, Nadir Shah**.

🎯 **Note the causal chain, which is a good Mains point:** *political collapse → artists lose patronage → migration → new regional schools.* **The decline of the Mughal empire did not end Indian painting; it decentralised and diversified it.** Cultural flourishing does not require political unity — the same argument you met in Class 6 Ch.9.

★ ★ The line NCERT insists on — do not skip it

"Remember that ORDINARY WOMEN AND MEN PAINTED AS WELL — on POTS, WALLS OF HOUSES, FLOORS, CLOTH — works of art that have ONLY OCCASIONALLY SURVIVED, unlike the miniatures that were CAREFULLY PRESERVED IN PALACES FOR CENTURIES."

★ ★ **This is the "silence of the sources" lesson (Class 6 Ch.1) applied to art history,** and it's a superb one-line answer to NCERT's question *"why do we know much more about the cultural practices of rulers than about those of ordinary people?"*

The survival of art is a function of patronage and storage, not of quality. A palace preserves; a mud wall is replastered every year. Folk art traditions — Madhubani, Warli, alpana, rangoli — are **as old and as skilled**, and are simply **not collectible**.

6 ★ ★ A Closer Look: BENGAL

📖 How Bengali emerged

MID-1st MILLENNIUM BCE
 Early Sanskrit texts suggest the people of Bengal
 *** DID NOT SPEAK SANSKRITIC LANGUAGES ***

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4th - 3rd CENTURIES BCE
 COMMERCIAL TIES develop between BENGAL and MAGADHA
 (south Bihar) -- may have led to growing Sanskrit influence

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 v

4th CENTURY CE
 The GUPTA rulers establish political control over NORTH BENGAL
 and begin to *** SETTLE BRAHMANAS *** there
 -> linguistic influence of the mid-Ganga valley grows stronger

|
 v

7th CENTURY
 The Chinese traveller *** XUAN ZANG *** observed that
 LANGUAGES RELATED TO SANSKRIT were in use ALL OVER BENGAL

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 v

8th CENTURY onward : the PALAS
 14th - 16th CENTURIES : SULTANS independent of Delhi
 1586 : *** AKBAR conquers Bengal *** -> nucleus of the BENGAL SUBA

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 v

*** While PERSIAN was the language of ADMINISTRATION,
 BENGALI developed as a REGIONAL LANGUAGE ***

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By the 15th CENTURY the Bengali group of DIALECTS was united by
 a COMMON LITERARY LANGUAGE based on the spoken language of the
 WESTERN part of the region (now West Bengal)

★ And the crucial nuance: although Bengali is **derived from Sanskrit**, it **passed through several stages of evolution**, and a wide range of **NON-Sanskrit words** — from **TRIBAL LANGUAGES**, **PERSIAN** and **EUROPEAN LANGUAGES** — became part of modern Bengali.

🎯 A language is a **layered deposit**, not a pure descent. Excellent for Essay on language, identity and purity claims.

📖 ★ ★ Two categories of early Bengali literature

	CATEGORY 1: indebted to Sanskrit	CATEGORY 2: independent of Sanskrit
Contents	Translations of the Sanskrit epics; the ★ MANGALAKAVYAS (literally "auspicious poems", dealing with local deities); bhakti literature such as biographies of ★ CHAITANYADEVA , leader of the Vaishnava bhakti movement (Ch.6)	★ NATH literature — the songs of MAYNAMATI and GOPICHANDRA ; stories concerning the worship of ★ DHARMA THAKUR ; fairy tales, folk tales and ballads
Dating	★ Easier to date — several manuscripts have been found	★ Circulated ORALLY and CANNOT BE PRECISELY DATED
Where popular	—	★ Particularly popular in EASTERN BENGAL , where the influence of BRAHMANAS was relatively WEAK

Background: the **Naths** were **ascetics who engaged in a variety of yogic practices** (Ch.6). The song of **Maynamati** — a queen who **encouraged her son Gopichandra to adopt the path of asceticism** — was

often enacted. Dharma Thakur is a popular regional deity, often worshipped in the form of a STONE or a PIECE OF WOOD.

🎯 **The correlation is the point:** the oral, non-Sanskritic literature was strongest **exactly where Brahmana influence was weakest**. Textual culture and social power map onto each other — and it explains NCERT's question *"why do you think the second category of texts was not written down?"*

🏠 ★ ★ **Pirs and the peopling of eastern Bengal**

FROM THE 16th CENTURY
People migrate in large numbers from the LESS FERTILE
WESTERN Bengal to the FORESTED AND MARSHY areas of
SOUTH-EASTERN Bengal
|
| They CLEAR FORESTS and bring land under RICE cultivation
v
Local communities of FISHERFOLK and SHIFTING CULTIVATORS,
OFTEN TRIBALS, MERGE with the new communities of PEASANTS
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| This COINCIDES with MUGHAL control over Bengal,
| capital in the heart of the eastern delta.
| Officials received land and often set up MOSQUES
| that served as centres for religious transformation.
v
The early settlers sought ORDER AND ASSURANCE in unstable
new settlements. This was provided by COMMUNITY LEADERS who
also functioned as TEACHERS and ADJUDICATORS, and were
sometimes ascribed with SUPERNATURAL POWERS.
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People referred to them with affection and respect as *** PIRS ***

★ ★ **And note how capacious the term was:**

The term **pir** included **saints or SUFIS and other religious personalities, DARING COLONISERS and DEIFIED SOLDIERS, various HINDU and BUDDHIST DEITIES, and even ANIMISTIC SPIRITS**. ★ **The cult of pirs became very popular and their shrines can be found everywhere in Bengal.**

★ ★ ★ **This is one of the most striking passages in the whole book.** A single honorific covered **Sufi saints, pioneer settlers, dead soldiers, Hindu and Buddhist gods, and nature spirits** — all at once.

🎯 **It is the best available illustration of how religious categories actually behaved on a frontier:** not as sealed systems but as **a shared vocabulary of reverence** that people applied to whoever gave them order and assurance. **Superb for GS1 on composite culture and syncretism** — and it pairs with the *dargah* in Ch.6.

🏠 ★★ The Bengali temple style

Aspect	Detail
When	A temple-building spree from the late fifteenth century, culminating in the nineteenth
Why	As in Ch.2 — built by individuals or groups who were becoming powerful , to demonstrate their power and proclaim their piety
★★ Who built them	Many modest BRICK and TERRACOTTA temples were built with the support of several ★ "LOW" SOCIAL GROUPS — the KOLU (OIL PRESSERS) and the KANSARI (BELL METAL WORKERS)
★ How they could afford it	★ The coming of the EUROPEAN TRADING COMPANIES created new economic opportunities; many families of these groups availed of them, and as their social and economic position improved, they proclaimed their status through the construction of temples
★★ The form	When local deities , once worshipped in THATCHED HUTS , gained the recognition of the Brahmanas , their images were housed in temples — and the temples began to COPY THE THATCHED HUT : the double-roofed (DOCHALA) or four-roofed (CHAUCHALA) structure
The four-roofed form	Four triangular roofs on four walls move up to converge on a curved line or a point ; usually built on a square platform
Decoration	The interior was relatively plain , but outer walls were decorated with paintings, ornamental tiles or TERRACOTTA TABLETS
★ The finest	VISHNUPUR , in the BANKURA district of West Bengal

★★ Two ideas here are exam-grade and worth stating explicitly:

1. **Architecture copied vernacular housing.** The temple imitates **the village hut** — a religious form built from a domestic one. *Dochala* = **two roofs**, *chauchala* = **four roofs**. Learn both terms
2. **Social mobility built the temples.** Oil pressers and bell-metal workers **got rich through European trade** and **converted economic gain into ritual status** by building temples. **A concrete, datable instance of caste status being negotiated through wealth** — outstanding for GS1

🔗 It also quietly foreshadows Class 8: **the European companies are already reshaping Bengali society before they rule it.**

🐟 ★★ Fish as food — the exemption

Fact	Detail
Why	Bengal is a riverine plain producing plenty of RICE and FISH — the staple of even poor Bengalis. Fishing has always been an important occupation
Evidence	Bengali literature contains several references to fish; terracotta plaques on the walls of temples and viharas (Buddhist monasteries) depict scenes of FISH BEING DRESSED AND TAKEN TO MARKET IN BASKETS
★★ The rule and its relaxation	Brahmanas were not allowed to eat non-vegetarian food , but the popularity of fish in the local diet made the Brahmanical authorities RELAX THIS PROHIBITION for the Bengal Brahmanas
★ The text	The BRIHADDHARMA PURANA , a ★ thirteenth-century Sanskrit text from Bengal, permitted the local Brahmanas to eat certain varieties of fish

★★★ This is the perfect closing example for the chapter, and a genuinely excellent exam point.

A **pan-Indian textual rule** (Brahmanas do not eat non-vegetarian food) met a **regional ecological reality** (a riverine plain where fish is the staple) — **and the text gave way**. A *Purana* was written to license the local practice.

🎯 The direction of causation is what matters: **local practice changed the textual rule, not the other way round**. That single fact demolishes any picture of a uniform, top-down Brahmanical order and is deployable in GS1 answers on the diversity of Indian society, on regional variation in caste norms, and in Essay on the relationship between text and lived practice.

⚡ UPSC FOCUS

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Mahodayapuram ★	Chera kingdom, 9th century , Kerala; Malayalam in inscriptions — among the earliest regional-language official records
Manipravalam ★★	" Diamonds and corals " = Sanskrit + regional language; text = <i>Lilatilakam</i> , 14th century
Jagannatha ★★ ★	"Lord of the world", Vishnu, Puri ; image still carved by tribal people ; temple by Anantavarman (Ganga dynasty, 12th c.); Anangabhima III, 1230 , made himself the god's " deputy "; Mughals, Marathas, EIC all sought control
Rajputana ★	British name, 19th century
Rajput heroic ideal ★	Death rather than defeat; recited by minstrels ; women and sati
Kathak ★★ ★	From katha = story; caste of temple story-tellers ; rasa lila in the 15th–16th c. with bhakti ; court form under the Mughals ; two gharanas — Jaipur and Lucknow ; Wajid Ali Shah , last Nawab of Awadh; preserved by courtesans ; classical only after independence
Six classical dances ★★	Kathak, Bharatanatyam (TN), Kathakali (Kerala), Odissi (Odisha), Kuchipudi (AP), Manipuri (Manipur)
Miniatures ★★	Water colour on cloth/paper ; earliest on palm leaf/wood ; western India, Jaina texts ; Mughal patrons Akbar, Jahangir, Shah Jahan ; seen by an exclusive few
Rajput centres ★	Mewar, Jodhpur, Bundi, Kota, Kishangarh
Basohli ★★	Late 17th c. , Himalayan foothills, bold and intense ; Bhanudatta's Rasamanjari
Kangra ★★	Triggered by ★ Nadir Shah, 1739 ; mid-18th c.; Vaishnavite inspiration; soft cool blues and greens , lyrical
Bengali language ★★	Guptas settled Brahmanas in north Bengal (4th c.); Xuan Zang (7th c.); Akbar conquers 1586 → Bengal suba ; Persian for administration, Bengali as regional language
Bengali literature ★★	Cat. 1 — epics, Mangalakavyas , Chaitanyadeva biographies. Cat. 2 — Nath literature, Maynamati & Gopichandra, Dharma Thakur , folk tales; oral, undatable, eastern Bengal
Pir ★★	Covered Sufis, colonisers, deified soldiers, Hindu and Buddhist deities, animistic spirits
Bengali temples ★★	Dochala (double-roofed) / chauchala (four-roofed), copying thatched huts ; brick and terracotta ; built by Kolu (oil pressers) and Kansari (bell metal workers); finest at ★ VISHNUPUR, Bankura
Fish ★★	Brihaddharma Purana, 13th century , permitted Bengal Brahmanas to eat certain fish

Traps:

- "Kathak originated in the Mughal court" → **FALSE**. It originated with **temple story-tellers**; the court refined it
- "Kathak has gharanas at Jaipur and Varanasi" → **NCERT names Jaipur and LUCKNOW** (a Banaras gharana exists but is not in this text)
- "Kangra painting is bold and intense" → **FALSE**. That's **Basohli**; Kangra is **soft, cool, lyrical**
- "Manipravalam means a mixture of Tamil and Malayalam" → **FALSE**. **Sanskrit + the regional language**
- "The Jagannatha image is carved by Brahmana priests" → **FALSE**. By **local tribal people**, to this day
- "Bengali temples were built only by wealthy Brahmanas" → **FALSE**. Many by "**low**" **social groups** enriched by European trade
- "**Brahmanas everywhere were forbidden fish**" → In **Bengal the prohibition was relaxed**, licensed by the *Brihaddharma Purana*

Mains

- ★★ ★ **Art & Culture:** "*Trace the evolution of Kathak and comment on the politics of classification as 'classical'.*"
 - ★★ ★ **Art & Culture:** "*Discuss the development of miniature painting from the Mughal court to the Pahari schools.*" — include the **1739 dispersal** as the causal mechanism
 - ★★ **Culture/Polity:** the **Jagannatha temple** as political legitimacy — why Mughals, Marathas and the EIC all wanted it
 - ★★ **Society:** "*Regional cultures are made, not inherited.*" Use Malayalam, Bengali, Kathak and the Bengali temple
 - ★★ **Society/Gender:** the Rajput heroic ideal and its cost to women; the road to the abolition of sati
 - ★ **Historiography:** why elite art survives and folk art does not
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Glossary

Term	Meaning
Manipravalam	"Diamonds and corals" — Sanskrit mixed with a regional language
Lilatilakam	14th-c. Manipravalam text on grammar and poetics
Jagannatha	"Lord of the world"; a name for Vishnu
Minstrel	A trained reciter of heroic poems and songs
Sati	Immolation of a widow on her husband's funeral pyre
Katha / Kathak	Story / the caste of temple story-tellers, and the dance
Rasa lila	Folk plays enacting Radha–Krishna legends
Gharana	A distinct school or tradition of performance
Miniature	A small painting in water colour on cloth or paper
Basohli	Bold, intense Pahari painting style, late 17th c.
Rasamanjari	Bhanudatta's text, the favourite Basohli subject
Kangra	Soft, lyrical Pahari school, mid-18th c., Vaishnavite themes
Mangalakavya	"Auspicious poem" on local deities, in Bengali
Nath literature	Songs and stories of the Nath ascetics
Dharma Thakur	A Bengali regional deity worshipped as a stone or piece of wood
Pir	A revered community leader — Sufi, settler, soldier, deity or spirit
Animism	Belief that natural objects and phenomena possess spirits
Dochala / Chauchala	Double-roofed / four-roofed Bengali temple form
Kolu / Kansari	Oil pressers / bell metal workers
Brihaddharma Purana	13th-c. Bengali Sanskrit text permitting fish to Brahmanas

2-MINUTE RECAP

- ★ **Regional cultures were MADE, not inherited** — frontiers evolved, and cultures are products of **intermixing local traditions with outside ideas**.
- Cheras of Mahodayapuram (9th c.)** put **Malayalam in their inscriptions** — among the earliest official uses of a regional language. **Manipravalam** ("diamonds and corals") = **Sanskrit + regional language**; the **Lilatilakam** (14th c.).
- Jagannatha at Puri** was probably a **tribal deity** — **tribal people still carve the image** — later identified with **Vishnu**. **Anantavarman** built the temple; **Anangabhima III (1230)** made himself the god's **deputy**. **Mughals, Marathas and the EIC** all tried to control it, because **legitimacy lived there**.
- Rajput heroism**: death before defeat, sung by **minstrels**; women were drawn in through **sati** — "those who followed the heroic ideal often had to pay for it with their lives."
- Kathak**: from **katha** (story) and temple **story-tellers** → **rasa lila** under **bhakti** (15th–16th c.) → **Mughal court** → **two gharanas, Jaipur and Lucknow (Wajid Ali Shah)** → disfavoured by the British, **kept alive by courtesans** → **classical only after independence**.
- Six classical dances**: Kathak, Bharatanatyam (TN), Kathakali (Kerala), Odissi (Odisha), Kuchipudi (AP), Manipuri (Manipur). ★ NCERT questions whether "classical" implies superiority.

7. **Miniatures**: water colour on cloth/paper; earliest illustrated **Jaina texts** in **western India**; Mughal patrons **Akbar, Jahangir, Shah Jahan**; seen by **an exclusive few**.
8. **Mughal decline dispersed the painters** → Deccan and Rajput courts (**Mewar, Jodhpur, Bundi, Kota, Kishangarh**); **Basohli** (late 17th c., **bold and intense**, *Rasamanjari*); **Kangra** (after **Nadir Shah, 1739**; **soft cool blues and greens**, Vaishnavite).
9. ★ **Ordinary people painted on pots, walls, floors and cloth** — it simply did not survive, because **palaces preserve and mud walls do not**.
10. **Bengali** emerged over a millennium — Gupta **Brahmana settlement**, **Xuan Zang's** observation, the **Palas**, independent **Sultans**, **Akbar's conquest (1586)**; **Persian administered, Bengali flourished**; a common literary form by the **15th century**; loanwords from **tribal, Persian and European** languages.
11. **Two literatures**: Sanskrit-indebted (epics, ***Mangalakavyas*, Chaitanyadeva**) — datable; and **independent** (**Nath songs, Maynamati and Gopichandra, Dharma Thakur**, folk tales) — **oral, undatable, strongest in eastern Bengal where Brahmana influence was weak**.
12. **Pirs** — a single term covering **Sufis, settlers, deified soldiers, Hindu and Buddhist deities and animistic spirits**; their shrines are everywhere in Bengal.
13. **Bengali temples** copied the **thatched hut** — ***dochala* and *chauchala*** — in **brick and terracotta**, often funded by **oil pressers and bell-metal workers enriched by European trade**; finest at **Vishnupur, Bankura**.
14. ★ **The Brihaddharma Purana (13th c.) permitted Bengal Brahmanas to eat fish** — **local practice bending the textual rule**, not the reverse.

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Manipravalam refers to — → *A style mixing Sanskrit with the regional language ("diamonds and corals"); the Lilatilakam was composed in it.*
2. Consider the following statements about the Jagannatha temple at Puri:
 1. The wooden image of the deity is made by local tribal people.
 2. Anangabhimha III declared himself the deity's deputy.
 3. The Mughals, Marathas and the English East India Company all sought control of it. → *All three.*
3. With reference to Kathak, which is/are correct?
 1. The term derives from *katha*, meaning story.
 2. Its two gharanas developed at Jaipur and Lucknow.
 3. It was recognised as a classical dance form during Mughal rule. → *1 and 2 only. Classical recognition came after independence.*
4. Consider the following pairs:
 1. Basohli — bold and intense style
 2. Kangra — soft colours and lyrical treatment
 3. Kishangarh — a Pahari school → *1 and 2 only. Kishangarh is a **Rajasthani/Rajput** centre.*
5. The migration of Mughal painters to the Himalayan foothills, which led to the Kangra school, followed — → *Nadir Shah's invasion and conquest of Delhi in 1739.*
6. The Brihaddharma Purana, a thirteenth-century text from Bengal, is notable because it — → *Permitted local Brahmanas to eat certain varieties of fish.*

Mains style

7. Trace the evolution of Kathak and comment on what the label "classical" conceals. **(250 words)**
8. "*The decline of the Mughal Empire diversified rather than diminished Indian painting.*" Discuss. **(250 words)**
9. Why did successive conquerors of Orissa seek control of the Jagannatha temple? **(150 words)**
10. "*Regional cultures in India are the product of intermixing, not of isolation.*" Examine with examples. **(250 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- What is *Manipravalam*, and which text is composed in it?
- Give three stages in the making of Kathak, and its two gharanas.
- Name the six classical dances and their states.
- Contrast Basohli and Kangra in one sentence each.
- Name the two categories of early Bengali literature with an example of each.
- Who could be called a *pir*?
- What are *dochala* and *chauchala*, and what did they imitate?
- What does the fish exemption prove about text and practice?